

Dadabhai Naoroji (1825–1917), a founding member of the Indian National Congress and the first Asian to be part of the British Parliament, was a businessman. He articulated the ‘drain theory’, which suggested that being part of the British empire was bad for India’s economy, as wealth from the country was being siphoned off to Britain.

Some of the best-known Indian companies in the world today—Tata, Bajaj, Godrej, Birla—were founded in colonial India. However, the government’s policies favoured European businesses, while Indians were restricted to operating in a few sectors. Indian industrialists had to cooperate with the British Indian government in order to ensure that their businesses could operate.

But in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Indian business leaders grew increasingly unhappy over the government’s bias against them. Many among India’s